LIQUOR ▸

Desi Twist

FROM AGAVE TO VERMOUTH, POPULAR WORLD SPIRITS NOW HAVE AN INDIAN STORY







India's craft revolution, in the past decade, focused on giving familiar categories of spirits a regional touch. Among gins, Hapusa became the world's first Himalayan dry gin, Baagh showcases the Nagpur orange, and GinGin and Satiwa use India-sourced hemp as a key botanical. Amrut Bella is the world's first jaggery-distilled rum, Rahasya vodka uses rice and grains from Punjab, and the acclaimed Godawan artisanal single malt whisky showcases Rajasthan's produce.

As our drinking culture matures, India is crafting niche spirits long defined by other countries. From Mexico's agave to Switzerland's absinthe, Italy and France's vermouth and liqueurs, and Japan's sake, several interesting liquids now have an Indian expression.

"Entrepreneurs have realised that traditional categories are quite tapped out," says Vikram Achanta, founder & CEO of Tulleeho. "The supply chain for competing international brands in these categories is often subject to vagaries, and they are under-invested in by MNCs or importers. This leaves the door open for Indian substitutes," he adds.

And so we have Maya Pistola's Agavepura, created from agave grown on the Deccan Plateau. Earlier this year, the country's first touji or certified sake brewer, Maia Laifungbam,

The Listicle

FRESH TABLES TO TRY ACROSS INDIA THIS MONTH



The Silver Train, Mumbai

Food from India's royal kitchens forms the basis of this menu in Lower Parel, featuring everything from Patiala Kukkad Laung Elaichi to Bhawani Singh's shami kebabs and the Prince of Wales Fish Curry. More unusual dishes include Nawab Wajid Ali Shah's Ande Ka Halwa and Jahangir's Benami Kheer (secret ingredient: garlic).

THE FLYING TRUNK, *Delhi*



Delhi's newest rooftop bar sits above Novotel New Delhi City Centre, offers 360-degree views of the city and even has an infinity pool. The menu draws inspiration from Asia's street markets, including the cocktails. Clarified Chai Spritz, anyone?

HOSA, *Gurugram*



ARUSH DUA

After making waves in Goa, modern South Indian restaurant Hosa (which means 'new' in Kannada) has made a promising debut in Gurugram. Signature dishes include the Elaneer Pepper Fry (tender coconut meat tossed with pepper masala and paired with akki roti), Pamban Chicken (skewers glazed with lemongrass jaggery) and Kari Dosa (see pic; mutton mince topped with bone marrow hollandaise and poached egg).